

JOHNWILSONYHAEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, we're talking with John Wilson from YHA, Youth Hostels Association of Australia and John, welcome to the program. Thank you very much for having me. Now John, I've had a good experience with YHA because being a travel journalist, I've stayed at YHA's all over the world actually, as well as Australia.

John, the network you have in Australia is absolutely fantastic for young people who are working or who are traveling around. Correct, yeah, we've got 18 properties at the moment around Australia. We are part of a wider global organization and that is Hostelling International with properties all over the world, but we focus on our 18 properties within Australia, both in some of the capital cities and we've got some other beautiful locations in places of natural beauty, national parks and so forth.

How does it work? You sign up for a membership, it gives you huge discounts in accommodation as you're traveling? Yeah, so anyone that stays with us is entitled to membership, so if you stay with us, give you a membership. Alternatively, you can purchase a membership and that's a nominal fee of only \$15, but that gives you access to a discounted rate at all of our properties and sometimes there's a little bit of a kicker on that as well. We do some offers throughout the year and you also get discounts on food and beverage now, where we have cafes, restaurants and bars.

That's a fantastic program and tell us about some of the locations. You've got all the major ones, Melbourne, Sydney, Adelaide, Perth, Brisbane. Favorite destination obviously is the one that's pictured here at the stand that's overlooking Sydney Harbour with a rooftop bar up there, but we have another larger property in Sydney at Central Station and we're about to open a new one right next door to Central Station.

That'll be a very big one in what's called Tech Central, which is a large software company, Alessina, building their corporate tower. We'll have a five floor, 137 room, 450 bed property in that building opening in 2027, but of course we also have properties in Brisbane, Melbourne and in other locations such as Byron Bay, so beachside, coastal locations, Newcastle, Koolangatta, Cairns and some of our smaller eco properties located in Grampians, Polo Bay and in Thredbo and a fairly unique one over in Fremantle, located in the prison, Fremantle Prison. The thing is when you stay in these youth hostels, you have a whole expert staff here there who can advise the visitors where to go, what to do in the relevant place.

Correct, we sort of pride ourselves on being safe accommodation. We also pride ourselves on housing young people, students, we do a lot of school groups with our properties, but we also host activities that are completely free to our guests. We of course can provide advice on what to go, where to go, you're staying in Cairns, you want to go on the reef, we can guide you as to the best places to get there, but we host activities in our properties that are completely free of charge

and they might be things like creative things, doing craft, we have Indigenous engagement activities in Cairns, we have an Indigenous organisation that comes in and does a welcome to country for our Sydney Harbour property, people are invited to go off-site where they'll do a bush tucker tour through the botanical gardens and that's completely free of charge, we provide that free to all of our guests.

It's just something that we can give back to our guests and also to the community as well. Tell us about a bit of the history of YHA in Australia, I suppose it started way back in the 50s, the 60s. So 1939 actually, we were incorporated I think in Australia, so very close to the sort of the launch of hostelling around the world, so we're just over 80 years old, we've gone through a bit of a change in that time, at one point we had about 18 properties around Australia, a lot of those were sort of more traditional sort of lodge type accommodation, we've changed that a little bit recently, our accommodations now, especially in some of our refurbished properties, have private rooms that are more akin to a hotel room, you'd walk in and think you were in a hotel, large screen TVs, ensuite bathrooms, desks, king queen beds, but we also still speak to our roots with dormitory style accommodation, bunk beds, we've been refurbishing some of those products as well, so our two Sydney properties, our Brisbane property and our Threadboat property have been completely refurbished and their bunk beds now have privacy screens, curtains and USB power points right next to the bed, which young people obviously glued to their devices, they need to be able to charge them, so we've facilitated that.

Because a lot of people think, oh I'm in a hostile situation, oh I'm sharing with a bunch of other people, but that's not necessarily the case, it's a fantastic value for money to get your own private room these days. Correct, and I think people really enjoy the ability of having that privacy, having a private room, some of the older travellers prefer that as well, who've been members for a long time, but also sort of the younger, you know, Generation Z travellers, some of them don't want to stay in shared accommodation, but they still want the community connectivity that they can get from the social area, the lounge area in the property, they also want to cook for themselves, so most of our properties still have self-service kitchens where they can cook a meal for themselves and share that with other travellers. I'm speaking with John Wilson from YHA Australia, Youth Hostels Association of Australia, and John, what are a couple of your favourite properties that really stand out for you? Yeah, I mean, a lot of us, we love a smaller property, which is actually on the screen just here, you can see, unfortunately obviously you can't see that over the radio, it's a small property located in Port Elliott, it's in an old heritage listed beach house, it actually overlooks the bay of Port Elliott, it's about an hour outside of Adelaide, it's a long way away from the east coast, but if we can get down there, we just love it, it's such a beautiful little location on the south coast of Australia down there.

John, how did you get involved with YHA? Well, I'm from Sydney, I'm a Sydney boy at heart, done a little bit of travelling and working around the world, I've lived here in London before, worked in hotels since I left school, a number of different roles throughout hospitality and came to

YHA about four years ago, always been doing revenue management and have now moved into sales and revenue management, representing YHA. I love the, it's a little bit different from working in hotels, you know, you're working more within the youth market, within a much broader range and broader demographic, and also we have 70% of our guests are international, which in Australia that's quite unique, you know, we're the first port of call often for many people who've come into the country, especially the younger crowd. And especially that audience who are doing the whole east coast run from Sydney up to Cairns, you've got places for them to stay right along the way? Correct, all the way, well you can go from Apollo Bay through Melbourne all the way up to Cairns, correct, via Sydney and Byron.

And how can people find out more about YHA Australia online, John? Yeah, we have a website obviously, it's yhaaustralia.com.au. Great, thank you very much for being on the program and YHA, highly recommend it, I've stayed at YHA's both in Australia and in Europe, and I can tell you that they're super clean, super beautiful, the accommodation is really fantastic, whatever your budget, whatever your budget, you can really help. Great, that's correct, thanks for having me, appreciate it.